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## From the editor-in-chief

It gives me no pleasure to say I told you so, but the media has been talking about the Naxalites far before the government paid full attention to them. We at INDIA TODAY have been writing about the Naxals every year from 1976 onwards. What used to be a movement centred around a single state, Bihar in the 1970s and 1980s, now controls 83 districts of the country out of a total of 220 within which Maoist cadres operate.

The INDIA TODAY database shows close to 50 articles about the Maoist movement between then and now and in each one of them we have been saying that the Government should step in and be proactive about the Naxals or their power will continue to grow.

Now, India—or rather the India that the Naxals control—is in quite another place. Its own citizens have taken up arms in order to defy authority and the law and control territory. More than anything else this is a reflection of the lack of development in remote parts of the country where the most impoverished live. No roads, schools, hospitals or even attention, and so it is not surprising that the poorest areas of the country are breeding grounds for Naxals.

The Dantewada massacre which took the lives of 76 CRPF jawans shows exactly how the Naxals have changed in the last decade. They are no longer a bow-and-arrow army. They have a good intelligence network and track officials far more smartly than officials track them. They train well using videos and modern methods, obtain arms from neighbouring countries and loot them off soldiers. They have become India's No. 1 problem.

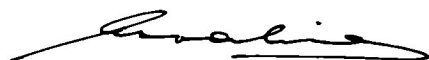
Now the chickens have come home to roost—we have ignored these people for so long that their numbers, anger and distrust is growing. A red corridor has spread like a stain from the deep south of Andhra Pradesh up to the northernmost border that Bihar shares with Nepal.

The Naxal violence that India is now struck by is more dangerous than that from foreign terrorists. We know who the terrorists are, we know their agenda and there are ways of dealing with them. No matter how devious they are, precautions can be taken. But no one knows exactly who or how many the Naxals really are and it is believed that more numbers are being added every week.

Negligent for decades, the Government now faces a classical problem: to offer development as well as take out the extremist element in the most extreme of situations. But the more violence is exerted by the state in places where people are struggling to make ends meet, the more it will alienate people.

Our cover story this week, put together by Managing Editor Shankkar Aiyar, talks about why and how Naxal terror needs to be tackled. We called in the best brains on the subject who make up the INDIA TODAY's BEST (Board of Experts on Security and Terror) to ask them to formulate a blueprint to tackle the Maoists. Dialogue, disarmament and fast tracking governance and employment were important components.

The Government must act with an iron fist and a velvet glove. Violence should not be tolerated but its root cause—the lack of development—must be swiftly addressed. Otherwise too much Indian blood will be shed.

  
(Aroon Purie)



OUR OCTOBER  
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